CASE STUDY · CLOUDFLARE ZERO TRUST

Why new IT admins stall before their first policy

I walked the public setup docs step by step and coded 60 public posts and reviews from admins who tried.

Independent concept. Public information only. Not affiliated with Cloudflare.

THE PATH TODAY

29 documented steps to protect one laptop

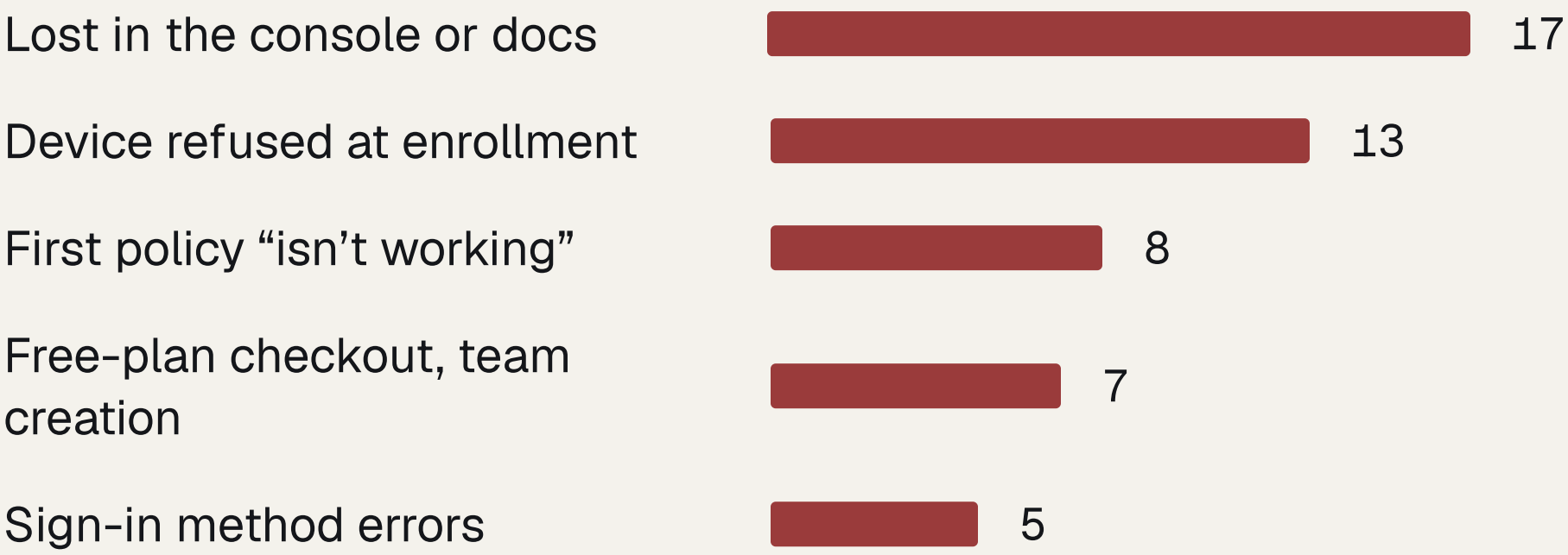
4	3	11	11
Team setup	Sign-in (PIN)	Enroll device	First DNS policy

Shortest path, across 5 doc pages. With Entra ID as the identity provider it is 50.

Counted from developers.cloudflare.com, 11 Nov 2026. One numbered instruction = one step.

WHERE IT BREAKS

56 friction signals, 5 themes



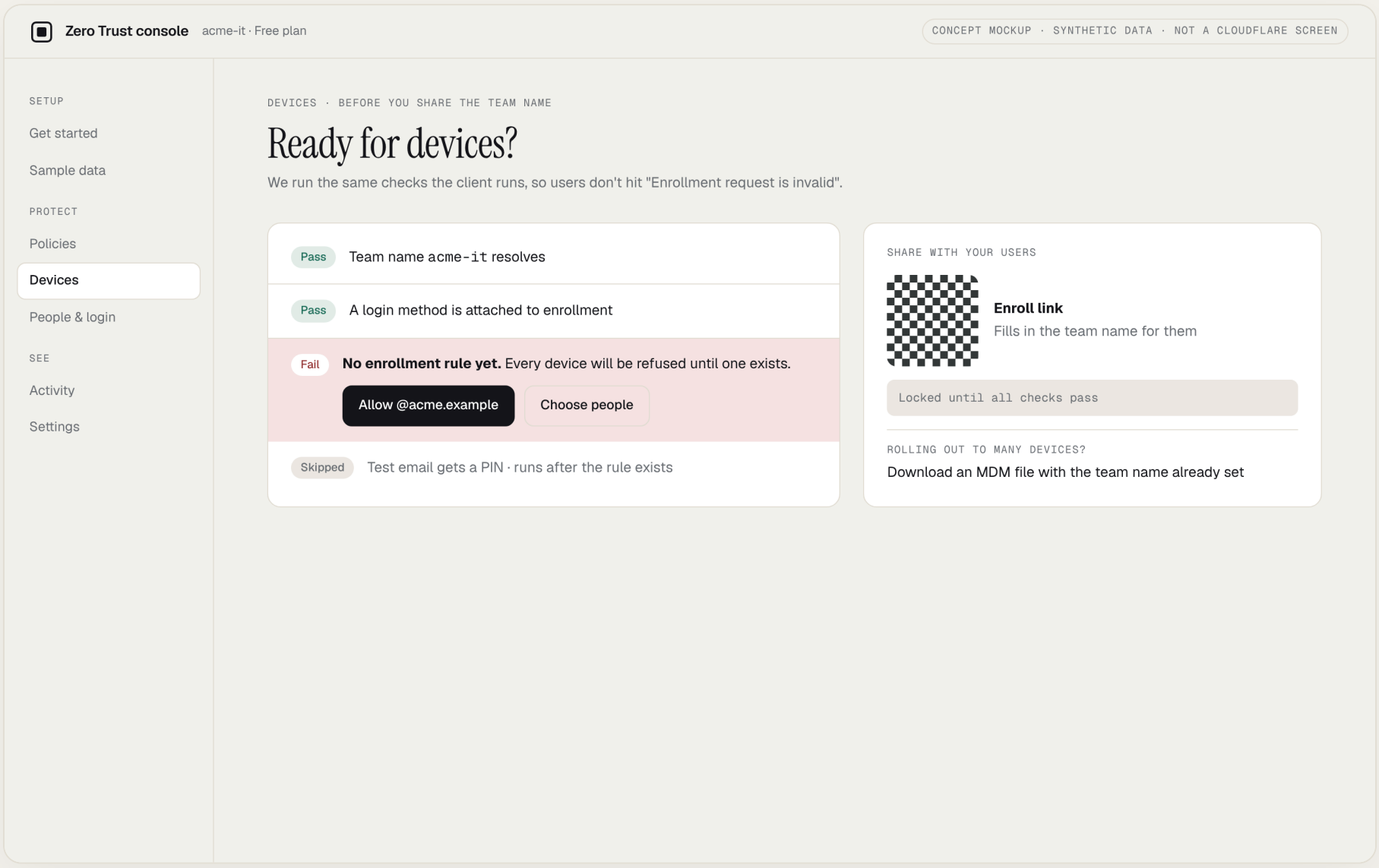
Cloudflare Community 33 · Reddit 10 · G2 9 · X 5 · Gartner 3. Posts come from people who got stuck, so these rank themes; they are not failure rates.

THE MOST SPECIFIC FAILURE

The quick start skips one rule

Device enrollment permissions live on a separate page. Without a rule, the client is refused before any sign-in screen.

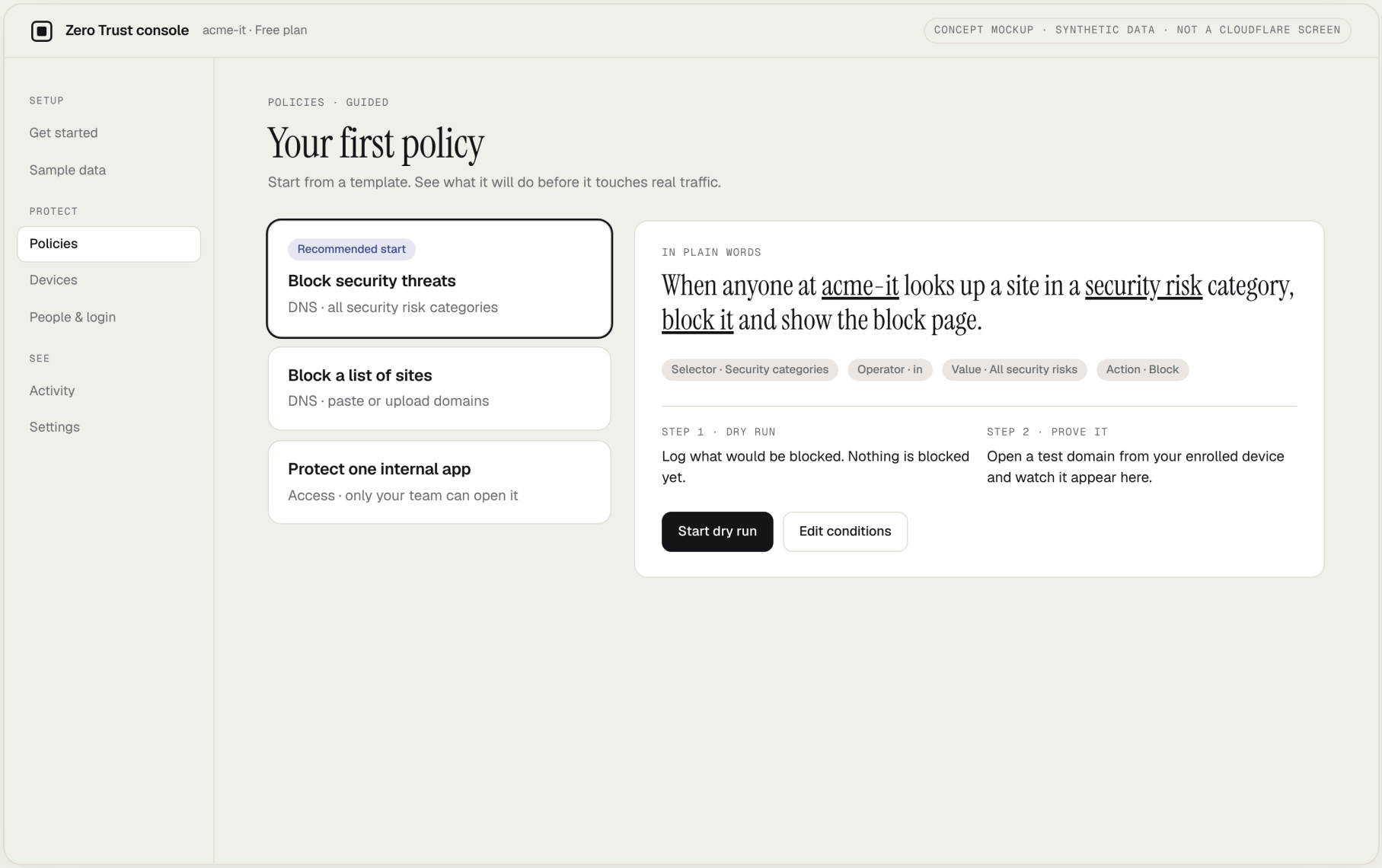
> “Enrolling any device fails immediately with ‘Enrollment request is invalid’”
>
> Cloudflare Community, Sep 2026



THEN: DOES IT WORK?

Prove the first policy on the test device

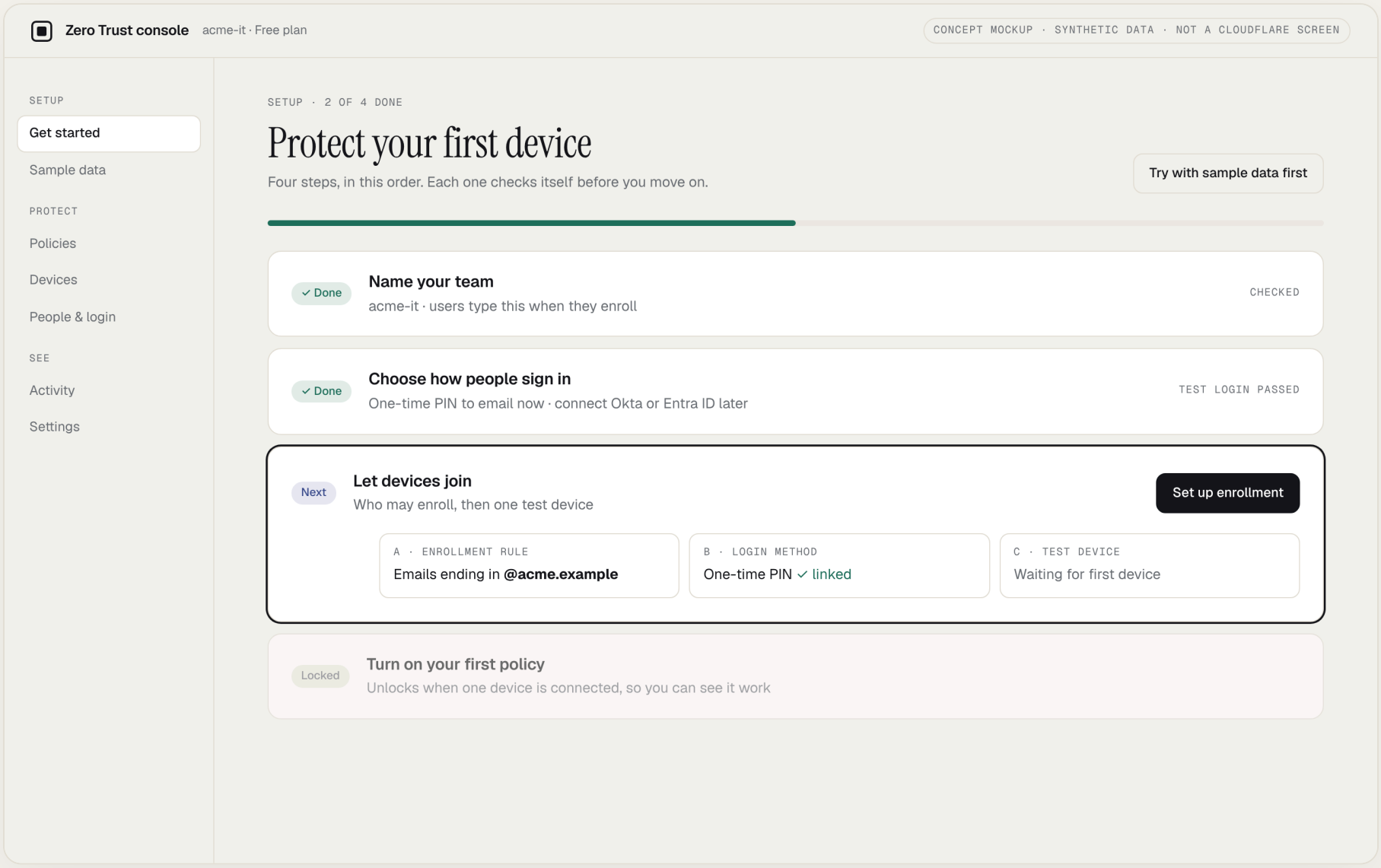
8 posts say a new block policy “isn’t working”. A guided first policy adds a template, a dry run, and a live check on the enrolled device.



LESS BLANK SLATE

A checklist that checks itself, and sample data

Each step is marked done only when the console sees the real config. A read-only sample org shows what a working setup looks like.



HOW TO MEASURE IT

One North Star, two guardrails

NORTH STAR

Activated accounts: ≥1 enrolled device and ≥1 enforced policy within [N] days of signup

INPUTS

Time to first policy · Checklist completion · Setup tickets per 100 new orgs

GUARDRAILS

Misconfiguration rate · Security incidents

Baselines and targets: [Team to decide] from first-party data.

WHAT I'D TEST

Two A/B tests

TEST 1

Guided checklist vs current console. Primary: activation within [N] days.

TEST 2

Sample-data mode vs empty state. Primary: activation within [N] days.

Sized with a two-proportion formula once the team sets baseline, MDE, α and power. Ship only if no guardrail gets worse.

Full case study, PRD and data: github.com/krupanirmal23/security-onboarding-case-study